

Tropical Storm Isaias Heads Toward the U.S. Gulf Coast

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Tropical Storm Isaias formed on Wednesday in warm ocean water off eastern Mexico. **Forecasters** expect it to quickly grow stronger and become the first hurricane of this year's Atlantic season before it reaches the U.S. Gulf Coast. **Landfall** is expected late Friday or early Saturday, though the storm's path and timing could still shift.

Michael Brennan, director of the U.S. National Hurricane Center, said Isaias could become a major Category 3 hurricane, with winds of 178 kilometers per hour or stronger, before it reaches land. The center issued a **hurricane watch** for the northern Gulf Coast, from Bay St. Louis, Mississippi, to Indian Pass on the Florida Panhandle. A watch means hurricane conditions are possible within 48 hours. **Forecasters** also warned of **storm surge**, when ocean water is pushed onto land, and of heavy rain that could cause **flash flooding** near the coast.

Communities are preparing. The governors of Florida and Alabama declared states of emergency for dozens of counties. "While I hope for minimal impacts, we must take preparations seriously," Alabama Governor Kay Ivey wrote online. In Gulf Shores, Alabama, organizers canceled the National Shrimp Festival, which drew an estimated 325,000 people last year. Some oil wells in the Gulf paused production, and eight of the Gulf's 371 staffed oil platforms were **evacuated**.

The storm might also disrupt Saturday's college football game between rivals Georgia and Alabama, which President Donald Trump has planned to attend.

This Atlantic hurricane season has been unusually quiet because a strong El Niño has disrupted storm formation over that ocean. If Isaias becomes a hurricane, it could tie or break a 121-year-old record for the latest first hurricane of an Atlantic season. That record dates to 1905, when the year's first Atlantic hurricane formed on October 8.

Word Treasure

Forecasters -- Scientists who study the weather and predict what it will do next.

Landfall -- The moment when a storm's center moves from the ocean onto land.

hurricane watch -- An alert that hurricane conditions are possible in an area within about two days.

storm surge -- A rise of seawater that a strong storm pushes onto the coast.

flash flooding -- Flooding that happens very quickly, often after heavy rain.

evacuated -- Emptied of people who were moved to a safer place.

Background you need

A hurricane is a powerful storm that forms over warm ocean water and has strong winds spinning around a calm center called the eye.

Storms start out as tropical storms and are called hurricanes once their winds become strong enough.

The Atlantic hurricane season covers the months when these storms are most likely to form in the Atlantic Ocean and the Gulf.

Forecasters at the U.S. National Hurricane Center track storms and issue watches and warnings so communities have time to prepare.

Break it down

LEAD: Tropical Storm Isaias formed off eastern Mexico and is expected to become a hurricane before reaching the U.S. Gulf Coast

KEY EVENT: Landfall forecast for late Friday or early Saturday

+ - WHO: Michael Brennan, director of the U.S. National Hurricane Center

+ - WHERE: A hurricane watch from Bay St. Louis, Mississippi, to Indian Pass, Florida

+ - RISKS: Possible Category 3 winds, storm surge and flash flooding

PREPARATIONS: States of emergency in Florida and Alabama, a canceled shrimp festival and paused oil production

CONTEXT: A quiet season because of a strong El Niño and a possible record dating to 1905

OPEN QUESTION: The storm's exact path and timing could still shift

Why it matters

Hurricane forecasts and early warnings give families, schools and businesses time to prepare and stay safe. The storm also shows how ocean patterns like El Niño can shape weather far away.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Tropical Storm Isaias form?
 - (A) Over the Mississippi River
 - (B) Near the coast of Florida
 - (C) In warm ocean water off eastern Mexico
 - (D) In the Pacific Ocean near Hawaii
2. When is Isaias expected to make landfall?
 - (A) Late Friday or early Saturday
 - (B) Sometime next month
 - (C) Next Monday
 - (D) Wednesday morning
3. According to the article, what does a hurricane watch mean?
 - (A) Everyone must leave right away
 - (B) Hurricane conditions are possible within 48 hours
 - (C) A hurricane has already hit land
 - (D) The storm is over
4. Which event in Gulf Shores, Alabama, was canceled?
 - (A) A presidential visit
 - (B) A boat race
 - (C) A college football game
 - (D) The National Shrimp Festival
5. Why has this Atlantic hurricane season been unusually quiet?
 - (A) There was no wind at all
 - (B) A strong El Niño disrupted storm formation over the Atlantic
 - (C) Forecasters stopped tracking storms
 - (D) The ocean was too cold everywhere
6. What record could Isaias tie or break?
 - (A) Most rain in one day
 - (B) Latest first hurricane of an Atlantic season
 - (C) Biggest storm surge ever
 - (D) Strongest hurricane ever

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Michael Brennan, U.S. National Hurricane Center: Says Isaias could become a major Category 3 hurricane before it reaches land.**
2. **Alabama Governor Kay Ivey: Hopes for minimal impacts but says preparations must be taken seriously.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):